

comes from fears about the future – one where I might be back in a dingy bedsit, unable to pay bills or, even worse, relying on a man.’

I discussed this with my husband, who grew up in a household where money was always very tight – though he always had everything he needed, he had an awareness of the scarcity of money and the need to work in order to earn it from a very early age. He described to me how spending anything above £30 tends to make him anxious, even now that he has a decent disposable income and no debt, and how any purchase above that amount makes him feel immediately guilty, even when it’s a necessary one. This leads to a reluctance to spend any money at all from his personal account for at least a few days afterward. He finds it easier with our joint account, he says, because the responsibility for what goes in and out of that account is shared, and not all on his shoulders.

Conversely, with money dysmorphia, you might be aware that you really can’t afford something – that the money in your account is spoken for already, or that your credit card balance is starting to scare you – but something pushes you to see it as free cash. This, quite opposite, experience is the one that I relate to personally. Looking back, I can see that I was painfully optimistic about my financial prospects, even when things were going very badly indeed. This optimism stemmed, perhaps, from the fact that I had never really been made to feel the impact of making poor financial decisions, and had been shielded from the financial difficulties faced by my family